Despite this pattern of partial involvement with other countries, Burma found a close ally in North Korea.[69] In many ways this exemplifies the self-serving pragmatism of their approach to international relations. This was a bumpy relationship that commenced in the 1970s with arms sales, but relations worsened after the North Koreans tried to assassinate a South Korean delegation in Rangoon in 1983. However, mutual interests brought the two states back together by the 1990s.[70] The Myanmar regime was happy to divert food from its starving population to pay for weapons and for some time explored the option of buying longer-range missiles and even submarines. This might have also included a search for a nuclear weapon,[71] but it seems most likely the regime decided against this, not least as it feared such a move would have challenged the Americans too directly[72] as well as worrying the Chinese and the Indians.

Ties with North Korea have become substantial and important to both countries. For example, Myanmar obtained help in an extensive programme of developing its own military infrastructure. In particular the regime wanted a network of tunnels to hide its equipment (including medium-range rockets) in case of an attack. Historically the Burmese army had been primarily an infantry force used in the border wars and for internal repression. The modernisation of the army and the adoption of modern weaponry and tactics have been linked to a desire to protect the 'leading role' in national politics allocated to the army in the 2008 Constitution.[73] Nevertheless, there is little evidence the Burmese army can use the highly expensive equipment they have bought from North Korea, Pakistan or Israel,[74] so the weaponry is probably more important as a status symbol than for actual usage.

In a way, Burma's relationship with North Korea captures all the contradictions of their approach to foreign engagements.[75] A degree of trading of food for advanced weaponry happened from the 1960s, not least as neither the USSR nor China would sell the Burmese regime missile launchers without also insisting on their own technicians being deployed, and not just for training, but to ensure control over usage. North Korea had no such requirements and was willing to approach the relationship as a purely commercial deal.[76] In effect, North Korea was an ideal partner. Unlike the US, it did not insist on at least lip service being paid to human rights, and unlike China it harbours no ambitions to link the infrastructure